

Jambo's Sadness





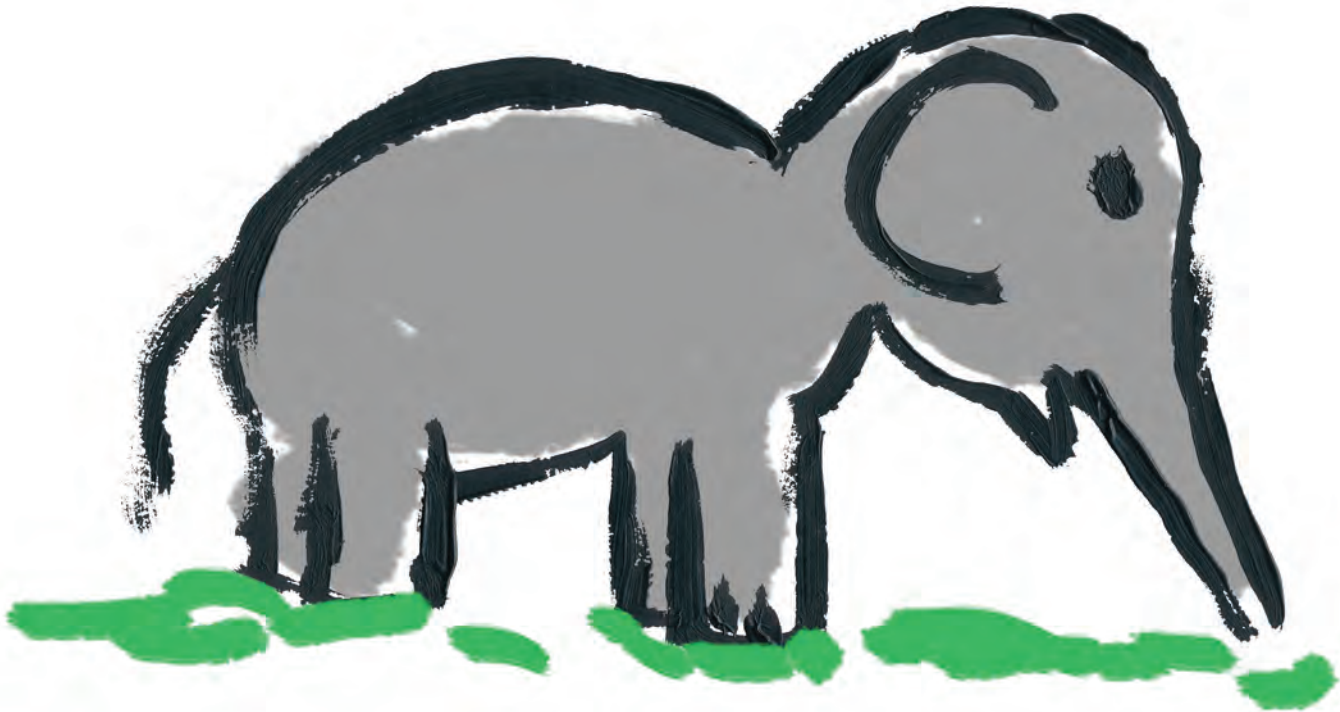
JAMBO'S SADNESS

Based on a true story from Rwanda

Written by David Wheen

Illustrations by Timo Greenwood

copyright © David Wheen December 2009



It was market day in Gitarambo. Women from this small Rwandan village were sitting at tables piled with fruit and vegetables.

The women laughed and chatted with their customers.

Suddenly the talking stopped. The ground started to vibrate and then tremble. The faces of the women grew taut. Nobody moved.

For into the market sauntered Jambo. A great African elephant.



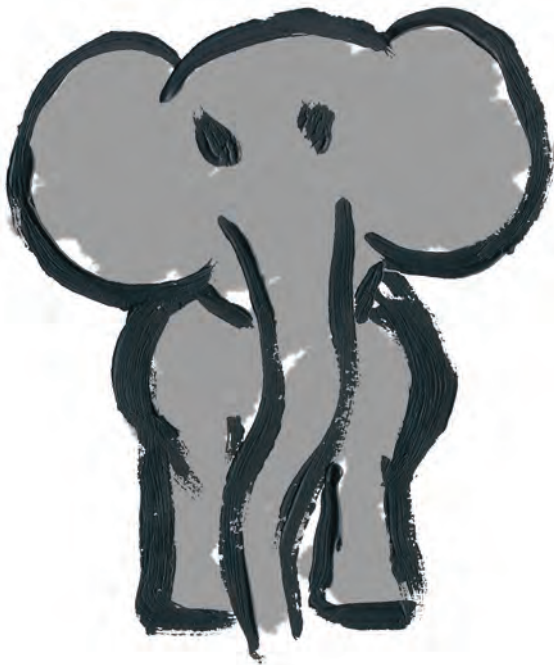


Jambo strolled between the tables, his small eyes scrutinising people and their produce.

He seemed careful not to disturb the tables or to touch the food.

But no one moved. They averted their eyes. No one knew what he might do.

An elephant is a giant who can be very dangerous if he becomes angry.



In the recent past Jambo had been angry and unpredictable but today he was just curious.

After several circuits of the market Jambo let out a gentle snort and padded away from the village and into the nearby park.



Relief was everywhere. Slowly the silence was broken. The villagers started to talk quietly.

One of the market sellers recalled how Jambo first arrived in the national park near the village 20 years ago.

As a young elephant he came by helicopter with two female elephants. They had been found in very poor condition in Burundi. It was decided to bring them to Akagera National Park in Rwanda in the hope that there they would recover their health.



The village of Gitarambo was close to the park. The local villagers became interested in the three new elephants.

A farmer named Moses took a special liking to Jambo and used to feed him bananas and cassava.

Jambo would often be heard trumpeting near Moses' farm telling him that he would love some more bananas.

Jambo and Moses became good friends.



Jambo also became friends with children from the village.

They loved to play with him. He was gentle with them.

Elephants have very long noses called trunks and they are so useful.

The children loved it when Jambo would swing them in his trunk.



They used to play games to see how small an item Jambo could pick up in his trunk. They put peanuts on the ground which Jambo picked up and transferred to his mouth.

This same trunk Jambo used for wrapping around a tree, ripping it from the ground or pulling down high branches so he could eat the leaves.



Not far into the park was a marsh. Jambo loved to play in the water.

The children liked to watch Jambo, especially when he went into the deep. All they could see was the top of his trunk. He used it as a snorkel as he swam.

Did you know that elephants can swim? Do you think Jambo swam elephant paddle?



When Jambo came out of the water the children ran from the marsh edge and hid behind bushes.

Jambo emerged, spraying water.

He then used his trunk to suck up dirt which he would also spray over himself. The children thought this a funny way to have a shower but Jambo seemed to smile and be so happy. The children didn't know that the dirt and mud was his sunscreen and helped repel insects.

Can you remember all the ways Jambo used his trunk?

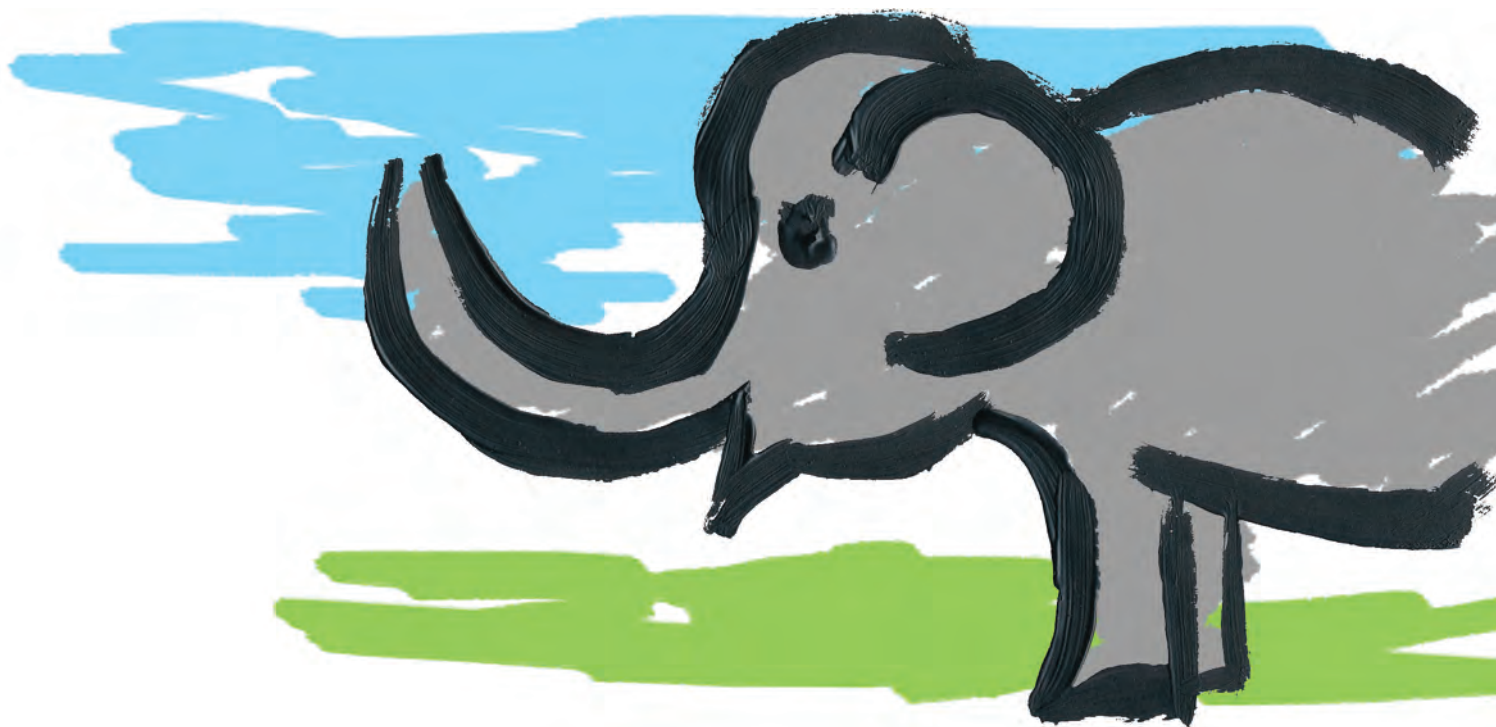


On the way home from the park the children sometimes played a game.

They would come across mounds of the dry poo Jambo and his friends had left.

With sticks they would pile it up and see who could jump over the highest pile. It would not be nice to fall!

Elephants eat about 130 kilograms of leaves, grass and bark every day so they leave lots of poo around.



Elephants talk to each other with a wide range of calls which sound to us like squeals, roars, snorts, rumbles, bellows and groans.

When they trumpet these sounds other elephants hear them, even though they may be kilometres away.

Over the years Moses and the children got to know when Jambo wanted to play. As he approached the village he gently bellowed and rumbled. This talk was recognised by the villagers.



Life for Jambo was happy. He had his elephant friends in the park and Moses and others in the village.

This all changed in 1994 when soldiers arrived.

Jambo became alarmed. He could hear guns being fired and saw big fires burning in the village.



The shooting went on for many days but then all seemed quiet.

Jambo wanted to see his friends again. He so hoped Moses would have a nice bunch of bananas for him.

As he came close to the village he suddenly heard gun shots. Bullets came whizzing close to him. Someone was shooting to send him away.

Jambo was terrified. Surely these were not his friends. He ran from the village and continued running until he was deep in the jungle.



Jambo stayed hidden for a long time. Eventually he decided he would try to see his friends again.

He set out for the village. As he approached it was so quiet. He thought this strange.

Where were all the children? Where was Moses?

He walked into the village. But it had been destroyed. There was no one there.



He padded past what was left of the school. There were no children.

He walked to Moses' farm.

Moses was not there. His house was burnt down. All that was left were a few banana trees.

Jambo was desperately sad. Where were his friends?

He took one last look at the village and then went ever so slowly into the park. If anyone had seen him they would have seen tears running down his trunk.



Jambo was now alone in the park. Not only had he lost his friends in the village but the other two elephants which had come from Burundi had disappeared.

They had become so frightened by the shooting that they had gone where Jambo could not find them.



Jambo was so unhappy he sometimes became very angry.

Other animals learnt to keep away from him. Now, instead of just bringing down branches to eat he would sometimes tear down swathes of trees and bushes and just leave them lying on the ground.

Using his tusks he would rip into big trees stripping off the bark.

His only friends were birds. A family of oxpeckers would ride on his back and pick ticks from his thick skin. A small flock of cattle egrets would keep close to catch insects he would flush from the bush.

Jambo was so sad.



Some years went by but Jambo still remembered the village and his friends. He did so want to see Moses. Elephants have long memories.

So he decided to visit his village again. He set off, accompanied by his oxpecker family.

When he approached the village he could see smoke curling up. As he went closer he could hear people talking.

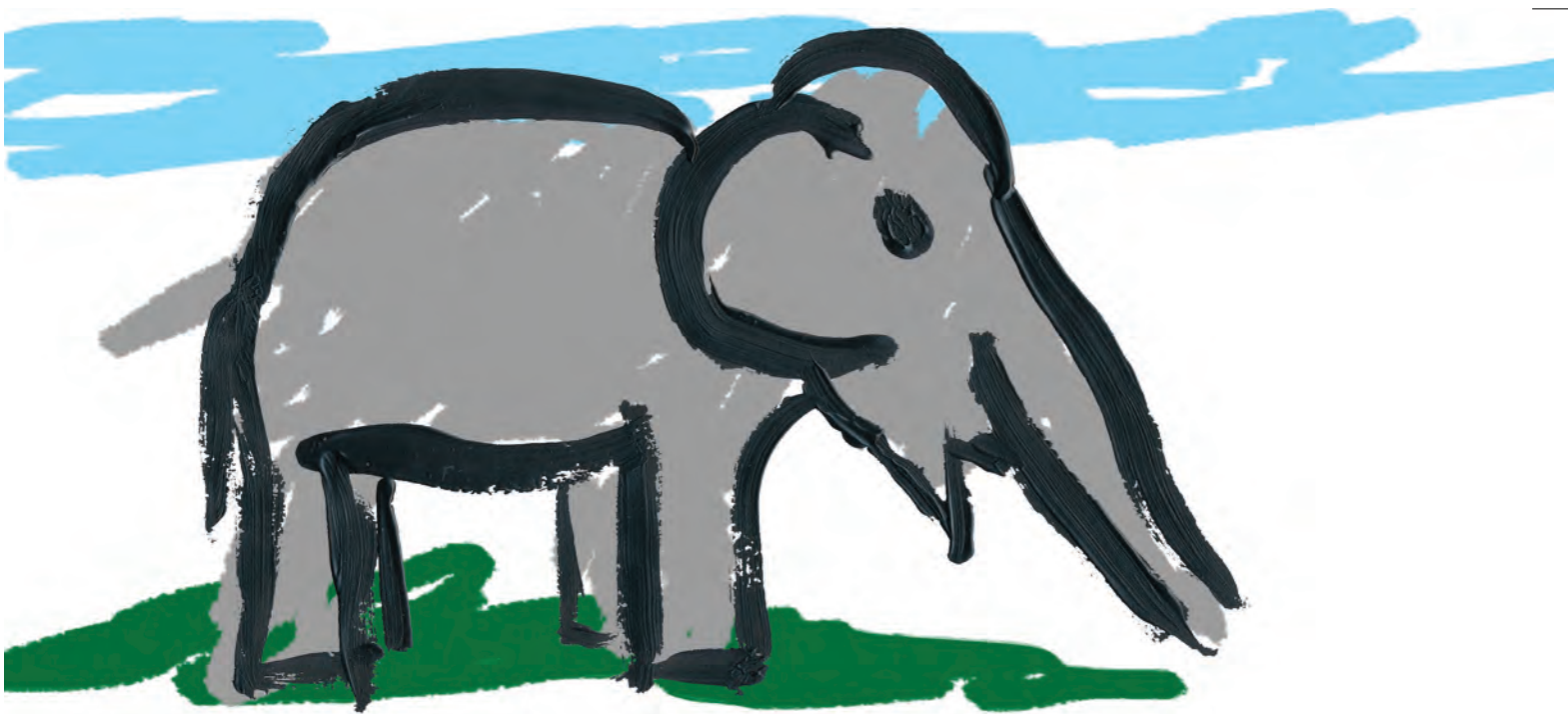


As quietly as an elephant can, Jambo entered the village.

He came to the school. There was only one building now and children were having lessons under the trees.

He stopped and searched the faces of children. He appeared to be looking for people he knew.

The children didn't move. They were scared. What would Jambo do?



But one girl slowly stood up.

She pulled a handful of grass and ever so quietly moved towards Jambo holding out the food.

The girl talked softly.

“Jambo, do you remember me? I’m Melody. You used to swing me in your trunk. You remember Moses. He is my father.”



Melody sensed Jambo was unsure what to do but after staring at her for a long time he swung his trunk and took the grass offered.

He slowly walked out of the village and back to the jungle.



Jambo now started to come to the edge of the village more often.

He would stand for a long time looking at the villagers. Although he seemed happy, people thought he was searching for someone and that it was probably Moses.

But Moses was not there. He was still in jail for, despite being such a kind friend to Jambo, he had done some terrible things to people during the war.



In the fighting some people called Hutus had attacked other people called Tutsis who had been their neighbours.

The Hutus had done this because they had been told by their leaders that their Tutsi neighbours were different to themselves and that the Tutsi neighbours were dangerous people who wanted to take away their homes and land.

Unfortunately many people believed what they were told. So lots of Tutsis and Hutus died or were badly hurt or had to flee from the village to save their lives.



When the war was over villagers started to rebuild their homes, dig new wells to collect water and buses and trucks started to travel through the village.

Sometimes a truck would backfire as it came down a hill. If Jambo heard this he would become terribly agitated and headed straight back deep into the park.

Villagers thought Jambo might think the noise was that of a gun shot which he remembered from the time of the war.



As the years passed Melody and her mother rebuilt their farm and started to grow bananas, cassava and other fruit and vegetables.

Every so often they would hear a quiet bellow from the edge of the farm and there would be Jambo. Melody would run out and give him a big bunch of bananas. Jambo would take these and slowly lumber back to the park.

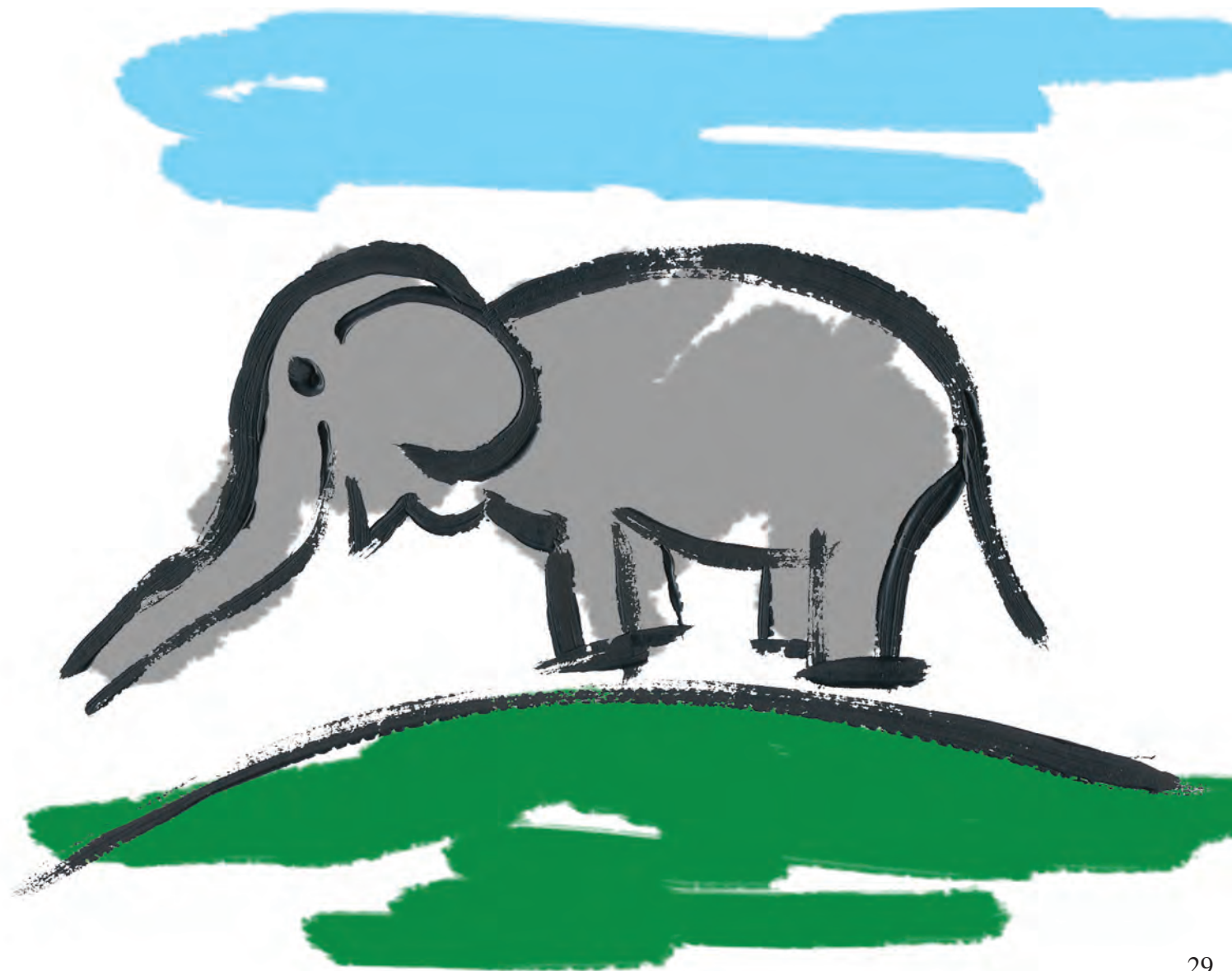


Early one morning Melody was wakened by Jambo's soft call.

She quietly went to her parent's bed and shook her father. Moses had recently been released from jail. He now had to work in the village as well as care for his farm.

Moses got up and went outside.

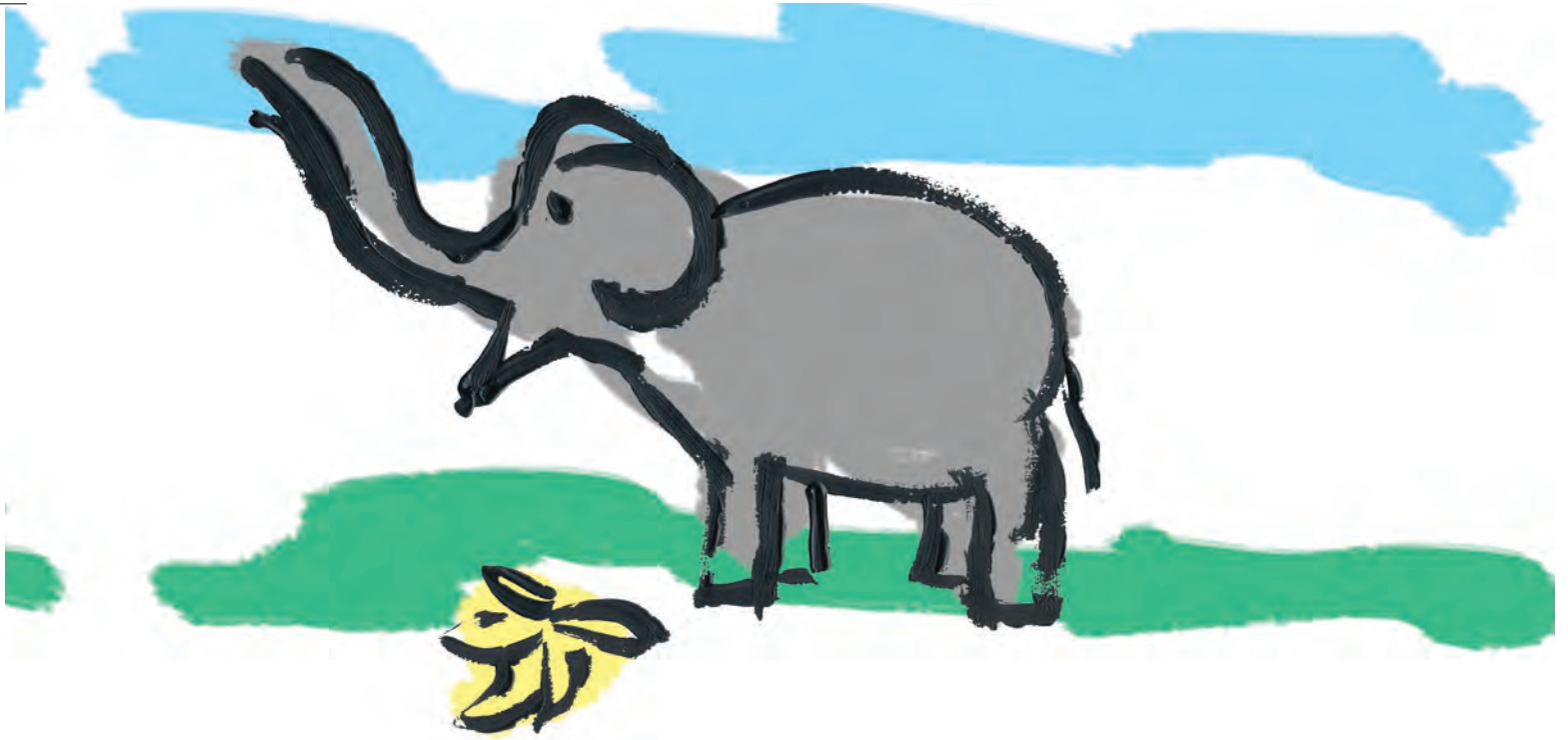
Jambo stared. There was something familiar about this grey haired man. Quietly Moses started to talk to Jambo.





Jambo cocked his big head as if to listen more intently. He suddenly let out a soft rumble for he recognised his old friend Moses.

Moses pulled bunches of bananas from a tree and gave these to Jambo. But Jambo didn't take them. He left them on the ground as he gazed at Moses who sat down on a stump and looked into the face of his friend.



The two old friends studied each other. They thought about the wonderful times they had had together. They were so pleased to see each other again.

Eventually Jambo raised his trunk, trumpeted so loudly that he must have wakened the whole village, swept up the bananas and strode off into the park.

Do you think Jambo was still sad?



